PERKALATE / EVENTS

How to Run Partner Funded Rewards at Your Event

A practical playbook for event producers and venues to run rewards that sponsors fund and verified attendees actually use.

Sponsorship has looked the same for a long time: a partner pays for space and visibility, and hopes the right people notice. Partner funded rewards flip that around. The sponsor pays for a reward that attendees claim and use on site, and everyone can see how it went. Here's how to run one well.

Start with the behavior you want

Before you talk to any partner, decide what you want attendees to do more of. Arrive in the first hour so the gates don't jam later. Visit an area of the grounds that's always empty. Stay through a slow slot between sets. Try the food hall instead of queuing at one bar. Come back for the second day.

A reward is a nudge. It works best when it points at one specific action at one specific time. "Free coffee before noon at the east stage" beats "a gift from our sponsor."

Find partners whose customers are already in your crowd

The best partners aren't just the biggest budgets. They're brands whose customers overlap with your audience, so the reward lands with people who already know and like them. A beverage brand at a summer festival. An outdoor gear company at a trail race. A card or loyalty program whose members are clearly in the room.

When you pitch, lead with the audience and the moment, not the square footage. Explain the behavior you're trying to drive, roughly how many attendees you expect in that window, and how you'll report results.

Verify eligibility, not identity

Partners want their reward to reach the right people. That doesn't require knowing who those people are. A good setup checks whether an attendee qualifies, for example whether they're a customer of the brand or a member of its program, and returns a simple yes or no. The attendee chooses to share, and the sponsor never receives a name or an email.

This matters for trust. Attendees are far more willing to claim when they're not handing over their details, and you avoid storing data you don't need.

Put the claim where people already are

Nobody at a festival wants to download an app, make an account and verify an email. Make claiming a few seconds long and place it in the flow of the day: signage at the entrance, a sticker on the bar, coasters at the food hall, a sign by the stage. A quick scan should be enough.

Brief your staff and the partner's team in one sentence each. The bartender needs to know exactly what to honor and when.

Use time as a lever

Rewards that work only during certain hours are how you shape the day. An early arrival reward spreads out gate traffic. A reward during a quiet set keeps people near a stage. A reward on the final evening encourages people to stay. Time windows also make results easier to read, because you can compare the reward window to the hours around it.

Plan the follow through

The event ends, the relationship shouldn't. Think about what a claimer gets next: early access to next year's tickets, a reward from the partner at their own store, a reason to come to your venue again. The sponsor cares about what happens after the weekend too, and that's a strong part of your renewal pitch.

A simple checklist

1. One behavior, one window, one reward per partner to start.
2. A partner whose customers are already in your crowd.
3. Eligibility checked with consent, no personal details passed on.
4. Claim points placed where people naturally stop.
5. Staff briefed in a sentence.
6. A recap promised before the event, with the numbers you'll report.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.